MODULE 03

Soft-maxxing

Posture, tongue, teeth, sleep, water: the quiet levers that change the overall impression.

Reading time	Budget	First visible results	Prerequisite
About 25 minutes	$0–20 / month	1 to 8 weeks	Module 01

BY THE END OF THIS MODULE, YOU'LL BE ABLE TO

Fix the posture habits that make you look shorter, tired and closed off.

Know exactly what mewing can and can't do, and practice the safe version.

Run a dental routine that keeps your smile clean, and whiten safely if you want to.

Get the sleep that changes how rested and healthy you look.

HOW TO READ THE LABELS

CONSENSUS Backed by research and professional guidelines.

PRELIMINARY Promising results, limited studies. Might be worth it, no guarantees.

WARNING Ineffective, risky, or both. Don't do it.

MEDICAL ADVICE This belongs to a healthcare professional.

3.1 What “soft-maxxing” means here

Online, soft-maxxing means everything that improves appearance without surgery. In this program, it means the **daily, low-cost habits** that change the overall impression you give: how you stand, how you breathe, how your teeth look, how rested your face is. None of them is dramatic on its own. Stacked together, they're often the difference between "looks tired" and "looks put together".

3.2 Posture

Why it matters for appearance

The most common pattern is **forward head posture**: the head drifts in front of the shoulders, the upper back rounds, the shoulders roll forward. Visually, it shortens the neck, softens the jawline in profile, narrows the shoulders and costs you some apparent height.

Correcting it won't change your bones. It changes how your existing frame is presented. That's an immediate, free win.

> WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS
>
> The link between posture and back or neck pain is weaker than often claimed: plenty of people with "bad" posture have no pain, and vice versa. PRELIMINARY
>
> What's well supported: strengthening the upper back and staying active is good for your body. And how you hold yourself clearly changes how you're perceived in photos and in person. We work on posture for **appearance and comfort**, not because slouching is "damaging your spine".

The 2-minute posture check

1. Stand with your back against a wall, heels about 2 inches (5 cm) from it.
2. Buttocks and upper back touch the wall. Does the back of your head touch it without tilting your chin up? If not, your head sits forward.
3. Gently slide your chin back (a "double chin" motion) until your head touches. That's your target head position.

Daily corrective routine (8 minutes)

Exercise	How	Dose
Chin tucks	Seated or standing, glide your chin straight back without tilting. Hold 3 seconds.	2 × 10
Wall angels	Back against the wall, arms in a W then slide up into a Y, keeping contact.	2 × 10
Band pull-aparts	Light resistance band at shoulder height, pull it apart by squeezing shoulder blades.	2 × 15
Doorway pec stretch	Forearm on door frame, elbow at shoulder height, step through gently.	2 × 30 s per side

Exercise	How	Dose
Dead hang	Hang from a bar with relaxed shoulders, or active shoulders if comfortable.	2 × 20–30 s

Rows and pull-ups in module 04 do the heavy lifting. This routine adds mobility and awareness.

Fix the environment, not just the body

- **Screen at eye level.** Raise your laptop on books and use a separate keyboard, or hold your phone higher.
- **Move every 30–60 minutes.** The best posture is the next one. Static positions are the problem.
- **Set a cue.** Every time you walk through a door, check: head back, shoulders down, chest open.

3.3 Mewing: what we know, and its limits

Mewing is the practice of keeping your **tongue resting flat against the roof of your mouth**, lips closed, teeth lightly touching or slightly apart, breathing through your nose. It's named after an orthodontist who claimed that this posture, held long-term, can reshape the face.

Claim	What the evidence says	Level
Resting tongue posture on the palate is the normal, healthy position	This matches standard descriptions of normal oral rest posture.	CONSENSUS
Nasal breathing is preferable to chronic mouth breathing	Widely accepted. Chronic mouth breathing can signal a nasal obstruction worth checking.	CONSENSUS
Mewing reshapes an adult's jaw or cheekbones	No controlled studies in adults show this. Adult facial bones have finished growing.	PRELIMINARY
Visible changes in a few weeks	Any quick change is posture or angle, not bone. Lifting the chin and pressing the tongue changes a photo, not your skeleton.	WARNING
"Hard mewing": pushing hard with the tongue for hours	Can strain the jaw muscles and joint (TMJ), and push teeth. No benefit to offset it.	WARNING

> **THE SAFE VERSION, AND WHY IT'S STILL WORTH DOING**
>
> Rest your whole tongue lightly on the roof of your mouth, lips closed, breathe through your nose. **Light contact, no pressure.** Don't clench.
>
> Why bother if it won't rebuild your jaw? Because it encourages nasal breathing, keeps your mouth closed at rest (which reads better than a slack jaw in person and in photos), and naturally pairs with good head posture.

See a doctor or dentist if you can't breathe comfortably through your nose, snore loudly, wake up with a dry mouth or headaches, or have jaw pain or clicking. Those can point to a nasal obstruction, sleep apnea or a TMJ issue. MEDICAL ADVICE

3.4 Teeth and smile

Your smile is one of the first things people notice when you talk. You don't need a perfect Hollywood smile; you need clean, healthy teeth and fresh breath.

The non-negotiable routine

What	How	Level
Brush twice a day	2 minutes, fluoride toothpaste, soft brush, gentle pressure. An electric brush makes it easier.	CONSENSUS
Clean between teeth daily	Floss or interdental brushes. A toothbrush can't reach the surfaces between teeth.	CONSENSUS
Don't rinse right after brushing	Spit, don't rinse, so the fluoride stays on your teeth longer.	CONSENSUS
Clean your tongue	A scraper or your brush. Most bad breath comes from the back of the tongue.	PRELIMINARY
Dentist check-up and cleaning	Usually every 6 to 12 months, as your dentist recommends.	CONSENSUS

Whitening

- **Prevention first**: coffee, tea, red wine, energy drinks and smoking stain. Rinse with water after.
- **Over-the-counter peroxide strips or gels** can whiten effectively. Follow the instructions exactly; temporary sensitivity is common. Look for products with the ADA Seal of Acceptance. CONSENSUS
- **Professional whitening** at a dentist is faster and supervised. Have a check-up first: whitening over a cavity or gum issue is a bad idea. MEDICAL ADVICE
- **Charcoal toothpaste, lemon, baking soda scrubs, vinegar**: abrasive or acidic, can wear down enamel. There's no good evidence charcoal products whiten safely. WARNING

Alignment

Crooked teeth can be straightened at any age with braces or clear aligners. That's an orthodontist's call. MEDICAL ADVICE Orthodontic associations warn against mail-order aligners without an in-person exam: moving teeth without X-rays and supervision can damage roots and gums. WARNING

3.5 Sleep: the most underrated lever

In controlled studies, the same people photographed after a normal night and after sleep deprivation were rated as **more tired, less healthy and less attractive** when sleep-deprived: hanging eyelids, redder eyes, darker circles, paler skin. PRELIMINARY

Sleep also drives everything else in this program: appetite control and fat loss, muscle recovery, skin repair, mood, and confidence.

Age	Recommended sleep	Source
13 to 18	8 to 10 hours per night	American Academy of Sleep Medicine CONSENSUS
18 and up	7 hours or more per night	AASM and Sleep Research Society CONSENSUS

The sleep checklist

Habit	Why
Fixed wake-up time, even on weekends (±1 hour)	Your body clock anchors on wake time more than bedtime.
Daylight within an hour of waking	Morning light helps set your body clock so you get sleepy at the right time.
Caffeine cutoff 6+ hours before bed	Caffeine taken 6 hours before bed still measurably reduced sleep in a controlled study.
Cool, dark, quiet room	Blackout curtains or a sleep mask, earplugs if needed.
Phone out of reach for the last 30–60 minutes	Less about blue light, more about scrolling keeping you awake longer than you planned.
No big meal or alcohol right before bed	Alcohol knocks you out but fragments sleep in the second half of the night.

If you sleep enough hours but still wake up exhausted, snore loudly, or someone notices you stop breathing during sleep, see a doctor: it could be sleep apnea, which is treatable. MEDICAL ADVICE

3.6 Hydration and puffiness

You'll hear that drinking gallons of water gives you glowing skin. In healthy people who already drink normally, there's little evidence that extra water visibly improves the skin. PRELIMINARY

- **Drink to thirst** and aim for pale yellow urine. More if you train, sweat, or it's hot.
- **Morning facial puffiness** is common and usually fades within an hour or two of being upright.
- **What makes it worse**: alcohol, very salty meals in the evening, short sleep, and allergies.
- **What helps**: sleep, limiting alcohol, a cold rinse in the morning. Not tricks, just less of what causes it.

3.7 Quick wins summary

Lever	Cost	Time to notice
Head and shoulder posture	$0	Immediately in photos, 4–8 weeks to become automatic

Lever	Cost	Time to notice
Tongue posture + nasal breathing	$0	Mouth closed at rest: immediately
Dental routine	≈ $10 / month	Fresher breath: days. Healthier gums: weeks
Whitening (optional)	$30–60 per kit	1 to 2 weeks
Sleep	$0	1 to 2 weeks

3.8 Your module 03 checklist

- ☐ I've done the wall test and know my target head position.
- ☐ I've scheduled the 8-minute posture routine (e.g. after brushing my teeth at night).
- ☐ My screen is at eye level.
- ☐ I practice light tongue posture, no pressure, nose breathing.
- ☐ I brush twice a day and clean between my teeth daily.
- ☐ I've booked or confirmed my next dental check-up.
- ☐ I've set a fixed wake-up time and a caffeine cutoff.

Sources

1. Watson NF, Badr MS, Belenky G, et al. Recommended amount of sleep for a healthy adult: a joint consensus statement of the American Academy of Sleep Medicine and Sleep Research Society. *Sleep*, 2015; 38(6): 843–844.
2. Paruthi S, Brooks LJ, D'Ambrosio C, et al. Recommended amount of sleep for pediatric populations: a consensus statement of the American Academy of Sleep Medicine. *Journal of Clinical Sleep Medicine*, 2016; 12(6): 785–786.
3. Sundelin T, Lekander M, Kecklund G, et al. Cues of fatigue: effects of sleep deprivation on facial appearance. *Sleep*, 2013; 36(9): 1355–1360.
4. Axelsson J, Sundelin T, Ingre M, et al. Beauty sleep: experimental study on the perceived health and attractiveness of sleep deprived people. *BMJ*, 2010; 341: c6614.
5. Drake C, Roehrs T, Shambroom J, Roth T. Caffeine effects on sleep taken 0, 3, or 6 hours before going to bed. *Journal of Clinical Sleep Medicine*, 2013; 9(11): 1195–1200.
6. Brooks JK, Bashirelahi N, Reynolds MA. Charcoal and charcoal-based dentifrices: a literature review. *Journal of the American Dental Association*, 2017; 148(9): 661–670.
7. American Dental Association. Home oral care recommendations. mouthhealthy.org.

This module is for aesthetic and educational purposes only. It does not replace advice from a qualified healthcare professional.